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Two More Years

Reappointment as Governor in 2011

My first appointment as governor in September 2008 was for a term of three years. When I went to see Finance Minister Chidambaram the morning after the appointment was announced, I had many things on my mind to check with him, almost all of them of immediate concern, such as the logistics of the transition. There were also many issues on which I had to brief him before handing over to my successor as finance secretary. The term of my appointment was nowhere on my agenda. However, he himself kindly volunteered: ‘You know, we appointed you only for three years. But don’t worry too much about it. You’ll surely get an extension.’ Worry about it? I had far too many more immediate worries. I forgot about that bit of conversation even before I exited his office.

The inevitable speculation about my extension[1] and the kite-flying on a putative successor started as early as March 2011, a full six months before the close of my term. I was not much distracted by this; indeed, I was surprised by my own indifference because it was so unlike me. I wouldn’t admit to being a careerist, but all through my career, I had clear aspirations and cared very much about my career progression. So, what explains this uncharacteristic nonchalance? I figured that by way of a career, I got more than my due from the government, and should they decide to replace me, I was prepared to hang up my boots and move on.

But was I prepared to accept an extension if it were offered? Only a few people were close enough to ask me this bluntly, Urmila among them. My answer was a clear yes. I had weathered the global financial crisis and was